Forcing the Spring: *Inside the Fight for Marriage Equality*

End Punctuation

A sentence ends with a period, a question mark, or an exclamation point.

- A **period** ends declarative (statement) and imperative (command) sentences:

  The administration canceled classes.

  Do not attempt to drive to school this morning.

- A **question mark** ends a direct question and indicates uncertainty in dates:

  Where is Times Square?

  She asked, "What time is it?"

- An **exclamation point** ends an emphatic or emotional sentence:

  "What a mess!" she blurted out.

  "Stop! That hurts!" he shouted.

Dashes and Parentheses

Dashes and parentheses enclose nonessential information in a sentence.

- Use a **dash** or dashes to set off nonessential information, to indicate a contrast or a pause, or to mark a change of direction.

  We did not notice the rain at first—it began so softly—but soon we were soaked.

  Nothing is as exciting as seeing a snowy owl in a winter farm field—except maybe seeing two snowy owls.

- Use **parentheses** to enclose nonessential information such as explanations, asides, examples, and dates.

  He graduated with high honors (*magna cum laude*) and found a job immediately.

  The city of Madison (home of the University of Wisconsin) is the state capital of Wisconsin.

H 10. Mechanics

Capital Letters

Use capital letters in the following situations.

- **Capitalize the first word of a sentence:** The weather is rainy today.
- **Capitalize proper nouns and proper adjectives:** Monday, New Orleans, Mexico, Florida, Halloween, United States Constitution, Department of Education, University of Texas, Native American, Islam, Italian, Freudian.
- **Capitalize titles that precede a person's name:** Dr. Atul Gawande, Senator Tammy Baldwin. [But: Atul Gawande, a doctor; Tammy Baldwin, a senator]

Many online resources, such as this one (https://openstax.org/r/this-one), list words that should be capitalized. You can also consult a dictionary, such as Merriam-Webster (https://openstax.org/r/Merriam-Webster), to determine whether to capitalize a word.

Titles of Works

Titles of books, articles, stories, plays, poems, films, and other works are handled differently depending on the documentation style you are using. The guidelines here follow MLA style.

Capitalization in Titles and Subtitles

Capitalize the first and last words in a title and subtitle and other important words. Do not capitalize **articles** (*a, an, the*), coordinating conjunctions (*for, and, nor, but, or, yet,* or *so*), or prepositions (*above, with, of, in, through, beyond, under*) unless they are the first or last words in the title or subtitle.

Forcing the Spring: Inside the Fight for Marriage Equality (book)
Judas and the Black Messiah (film)
"American Military Performance in Vietnam: Background and Analysis" (article)

Italics for Titles of Long Works

Use italics for long works that are published, produced, or released separately from other works. These include books, long poems, plays, movies, videos, published speeches, periodicals (newspapers, magazines, and academic and professional journals), websites, long musical works, works of visual art, computer software, TV or radio programs and series, and pamphlets.

Four Fish: The Future of the Last Wild Food (book)
The New Yorker (periodical)
The Los Angeles Times (newspaper)
American Idiot (album)
Parasite (film)
Saturday Night Live (TV program)

Quotation Marks for Titles of Shorter Works

Put quotation marks around the titles and subtitles of individual shorter works or those that are published or released within larger works. These include articles in periodicals (newspapers, magazines, and academic and professional journals), pages or works on a website, short stories, short poems, essays, songs, episodes of TV or radio programs and series, book chapters, and unpublished speeches.

"Living with a Visionary" (article in a magazine)
"A World of Fields and Fences" (work on a website)
"New York Day Women" (short story)
"Corson's Inlet" (short poem)
"Return from ISIS" (TV episode)

H 11. Quotations

A **quotation** reproduces the exact written or spoken words of a person or an author, which may include a group. (See Editing Focus: Quotations for a related discussion of direct quotations and Editing Focus: Integrating Sources and Quotations for help with integrating quotations from sources.)

Quotations from Written or Spoken Sources

Put quotation marks around quotations from a written or spoken source.

Quoting a Source

When quoting the words of a source, introduce quoted material with a signal phrase so that readers know the source and purpose of the quotation. Place the quotation inside double quotation marks. When using parenthetical citations, note that the sentence period comes *after* the parentheses. If you include the author's name in your signal phrase, give only the page number in parentheses (first example). If you do not give the author's name in your signal phrase, give the name in parentheses (second example):

In *Walden*, Thoreau sets forth one individual's antidote against the "lives of quiet desperation" led by the working class in mid-nineteenth-century America (5).